friendly companies—not just free meals, employees here get access to a fitness centre, spa massages, nap rooms and... can slide down to the next floor if they don't feel like taking the elevator. Yet, a decision to enforce stricter rules for in-office attendance led to an outpouring of discontent from staffers on various social media platforms in June 2023. Perhaps, the issue isn't so much the office environment as the task of getting to office in the first place. The report '2023 on Wheels: How India Moved in Sync', published by office commute platform MoveInSync, said that an average Indian spent 59 minutes to travel 20 kilometres one way to work. Indian employees spent 8 per cent of their time (almost two hours) travelling to and from office. "Most major cities in the world have traffic congestion issues, but drivers still follow traffic rules and maintain lines. In India, the stress is double because nobody follows any rules. You are always worried about somebody hitting your car or you hitting someone else's," says Sakshi Mehrotra, 39, who works at a global IT firm in Bengaluru. In 2015, a study carried out by Ford Motor Company in five Asian countries, including India, found that traffic congestion (63 per cent) and parking (56 per cent) top the list of factors that cause high anxiety levels in Indian drivers. And long commutes don't just negatively impact mental wellbeing. "Driving for long periods can cause musculoskeletal pain and, during high pollution months, it also increases exposure to harmful particulate matter," says Dr Vishal Rastogi, head of cardiology, Fortis Escorts. This could explain not only why WFH is preferable but also why nearly 70 per cent of the MOTN respondents would happily work longer hours to complete a 40-hour work week over only four days a week. After all, it would mean two hours less of sharing roads with rickshaws ferrying TMT bars, long-haul trucks, malfunctioning signals and the occasional cow.

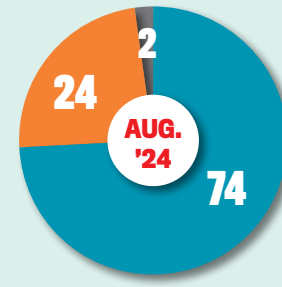
A SENSE OF SELF

Most respondents (62.7 per cent) are fine with working 40-70 hours a week, but those aged between 18 and 24 expressed a higher need (24 per cent) than any other age group to work less than 40 hours a week. There is certainly more interest amongst younger professionals in finding a sense of self outside of work. This could be the result of greater opportunities to pursue hobbies, travel, socialise or spend quality time in solitude. Then again, from sound bathing classes to speed dating nights, and from mountain hikes to private cinema screenings—a variety of niche experiences—are now both accessible and affordable. "The world is moving from ownership to usership. Conversations are now about something you did—a book you read, a new show you watched, a new place you went to. That is the new social status, what all you have done rather than what you wear, drive or where you work," explains

24%

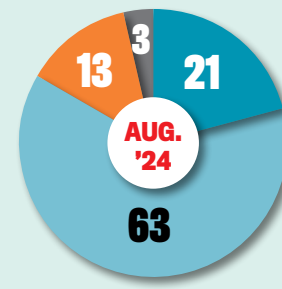
of those in the 18–24 age group, the highest across all age groups, want to work less than 40 hours a week to maintain required productivity at work and lead a happy personal life

Q. Is it possible to maintain a work-life balance with your current job?



Three-quarters are hopeful about achieving this vital goal

Q. What should be the ideal work hours to maintain required productivity at work and lead a happy personal life?



A majority sticks to standard hours of work; mostly the young want lesser hours